Pilgrim (You Can't Go Home)

A Companion Guide

Song by Dave Rawlings Machine

From the album Nashville Obsolete (2015)

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This is a full companion guide. As a song rather than a story, there are no plot spoilers to manage, so everything is on the table.

Quick Take

"Pilgrim (You Can't Go Home)" is the closing track of Nashville Obsolete, the 2015 album by Dave Rawlings Machine, and at seven minutes and fifty-seven seconds it is one of the longest and most ambitious things David Rawlings and Gillian Welch have ever committed to tape. Dave Rawlings Machine is less a side project than a costume change: it is the same decades-long Welch and Rawlings partnership, rebilled to put Rawlings' reedy tenor out front instead of Welch's. The song is a roving, hymn-like ballad about exile, wandering, and the impossibility of going back, and nearly every critic who reviewed the album treated it as the record's thesis statement. Nashville Obsolete earned what Metacritic calls "universal acclaim" and landed on Rolling Stone's list of the 40 best country albums of 2015. If you are drawn to long-form narrative folk, the kind that braids Biblical imagery and old blues standards into something that feels both ancient and freshly built, "Pilgrim" rewards close listening. It is worth your eight minutes.

The Source: Where the Song Actually Lives

A correction worth making up front, because it shapes everything else. "Pilgrim (You Can't Go Home)" is sometimes mistakenly tied to A Friend of a Friend, the 2009 Dave Rawlings Machine debut. It is not on that album. The song is the seventh and final track of Nashville Obsolete, the second Dave Rawlings Machine album, released September 18, 2015 on the duo's own Acony Records. The 2009 debut is a different record with a different character, built largely on covers and outside co-writes: a Ryan Adams collaboration, a Bright Eyes song, a medley folding in Neil Young's "Cortez the Killer." Nashville Obsolete is something else entirely. Its seven songs are all original compositions credited jointly to Gillian Welch and David Rawlings, and the album runs a deliberately compact forty-four minutes.

To understand the song you have to understand the "Machine." David Rawlings and Gillian Welch met as students at Berklee College of Music in the early 1990s, where he was a guitar-performance major and she was studying songwriting. They discovered their voices harmonized while singing the country standard "Long Black Veil," and the partnership that began at that audition has lasted ever since. For most of their career the records came out under Welch's name, with Rawlings as guitarist, harmony singer, and producer, his job to frame her voice. Dave Rawlings Machine flips that arrangement. Once they started building songs around his voice instead of hers, Rawlings has said, the old method stopped working:

> *"We had learned to make records in a particular way because we were always framing her voice. When we started working with my voice, nothing from that approach was valid. So we had to find different sounds and treatments."*
>
> *David Rawlings, American Songwriter*

The Machine is also bigger and lusher than the spare, two-guitars-and-two-voices Welch-billed albums. It is a full string band. And Nashville Obsolete turned out to be the last album released under the Dave Rawlings Machine name: the pair later returned to a straightforward shared billing, Gillian Welch and David Rawlings, for the Grammy-winning Woodland in 2024. So

"Pilgrim" sits at the very end of the Machine era, the final track of the final Machine album. There is a fittingness to that, given what the song is about.

The Song Itself: A Pilgrimage You Can't Walk Back

On its surface, "Pilgrim (You Can't Go Home)" is a wanderer's lament. The refrain keeps asking where you will run, where you will roam, when you can't go home. But the critics who sat with the song found it works on at least two levels at once, and the companion guide is more useful if it lays both of them out.

Reading One: The Sinner's Pilgrimage

No Depression's John Ellis traced the opening of the lyric all the way back to the Garden of Eden. In that reading, Rawlings frames humanity's expulsion from "home" as "the great escape," the original departure that sets up a life "fraught with loneliness because the poet ain't the tumbleweed." The pilgrim of the title is the oldest figure in religious storytelling: the sinner and seeker moving through a fallen landscape toward some promised rest. That is why one reviewer titled an entire essay on the album "An American Pilgrimage."

Reading Two: The Artist Who Can't Stand Still

The second reading is about Rawlings himself, and about the album's title. Nashville Obsolete worries openly about obsolescence, about an artist or a tradition being left behind, and "Pilgrim" carries that anxiety to its conclusion. As one critic put it, Rawlings "confesses his fear of being found so far afield as to be obsolete," yet the searching spirit will not let him settle. PopMatters read the title as a working creed:

> *"For music to survive it needs to keep pushing ahead. You can visit your home, but you can't dwell there."*
>
> *PopMatters review of Nashville Obsolete*

Put the two readings together and the song stops being simple nostalgia. "You can't go home" is not only a loss to mourn. It is also a statement of purpose. The exile is the point. You are not supposed to retreat into a comfortable past, as a person or as a kind of music, and that idea is what gives the whole album its name.

The Imagery: A Dense Folk and Biblical Pastiche

What makes "Pilgrim" so rich on repeat listens is how thickly it is woven. American Songwriter described the song as featuring "images of devils, Gabriel, St. Columba, angels, a golden calf, and a pillar of smoke accompanied by tight harmonies and a sad refrain." The lyric sends the pilgrim to "spin the wheels of St. Columba's and ride his golden calf," mixing Old Testament idolatry with a sixth-century Celtic saint in a single line. Elsewhere the traveler is found "gazing out of the window at St. James infirmary," a deliberate nod to "St. James Infirmary Blues," the much-recorded American folk-blues standard made famous by Louis Armstrong. Uncut singled this out, calling "Pilgrim" "a roving ballad that namechecks St. James Infirmary on its eight-minute quest for salvation."

This is the Welch and Rawlings method in concentrated form. The song is not a rewrite of any single traditional tune. It is a pastiche, built from what one writer called their "many nods and references to countless folk standards and 20th century traditionals." The effect is a song that feels like it was unearthed rather than written, even though every word of it is original. And for all the talk of devils and exile, it does not end in despair. The closing turn is an encouragement: keep rolling, rolling down that road that you're on.

The Sound

Musically, "Pilgrim" is a string-band ballad with no drums, which is what gives its near-eight-minute runtime that unhurried, roving quality. Rawlings takes the lead vocal in his distinct, reedy tenor, with Welch wrapped close around him in the harmony role she usually leads. Reviewers reached for words like "brooding grandeur" for the album as a whole, and "Pilgrim," as its longest statement of purpose and its final word, earns that description more than any other track.

Critical Reception

Nashville Obsolete was a genuine critical step up from the 2009 debut, and it was received as a serious artistic statement rather than a between-albums diversion. It holds a Metacritic score of 87 out of 100, which the site labels "universal acclaim," drawn from seven reviews, all seven of them positive.

PopMatters and Exclaim both scored it 90. PopMatters called the record "a bold step forward for the ever-broadening world of folk, Americana, and newgrass." Exclaim praised the duo's gift for borrowing without sounding stale:

> *"Rawlings and Welch are so good and natural in their borrowing that Nashville Obsolete evokes familiar, sepia-toned moods almost without ever sounding worn-out or dated."*
>
> *Exclaim review of Nashville Obsolete*

AllMusic gave it 80 and caught the album's mood precisely, writing that "Nashville Obsolete has something of a brooding grandeur to it." Glide Magazine landed at 7 out of 10. Beyond the review outlets, Rolling Stone named it one of the 40 best country albums of 2015.

For a song-focused guide, the most telling detail is how often critics singled out "Pilgrim" specifically. PopMatters wrote that the closing track "neatly sums up why this album can safely be proclaimed as a bold step forward," showing how old-fashioned lonesome melodies could "join forces with the freewheeling liberties of outside musical genres." No Depression treated the "you can't go home" refrain as the line that encapsulates the album's entire thematic arc. This is not a deep cut. Multiple reviewers heard it as the song that defines the record.

What You Might Not Know

The Studio Has Its Own History

Nashville Obsolete was recorded analog, straight to tape, at Woodland Sound Studios in East Nashville, with Rawlings producing. The building is a character in its own right. It opened in 1924 as the Woodland Theatre, a 500-seat movie house, and was converted into a recording studio in 1967 by engineer Glenn Snoddy. Records cut there over the decades include Kansas's "Dust in the Wind," the Charlie Daniels Band's "The Devil Went Down to Georgia," the Oak Ridge Boys' "Elvira," and the Nitty Gritty Dirt Band's landmark "Will the Circle Be Unbroken." Welch and Rawlings bought the shuttered building in 2002, partly out of loyalty to memories of recording Welch's 1996 debut Revival there with T Bone Burnett. In March 2020 an EF-3 tornado tore the roof off the place, and the couple spent the next four years rebuilding it, a saga that became the subject of their 2024 album Woodland.

The string parts on Nashville Obsolete were overdubbed separately at Royal Studios in Memphis, and the record was mastered at Marcussen Mastering in Los Angeles. Everything was released through Acony Records, the independent label Welch and Rawlings founded and still run.

Who Is Actually Playing

The core of the band is Rawlings on guitar and lead vocal and Welch on harmony vocal and guitar. The expanded "Machine" lineup adds Willie Watson, a co-founder of Old Crow Medicine Show, on guitar and vocals, and Paul Kowert, the bassist of the Punch Brothers, on upright bass, with guest turns from Brittany Haas on fiddle and Jordan Tice on mandolin. An eight-piece string section, arranged by Rawlings, was overdubbed in Memphis. This is a leaner, more string-driven cast than the 2009 debut, which had leaned on the full Old Crow rhythm section and guests like Benmont Tench of Tom Petty's Heartbreakers.

The Guitar

A surprising amount of the Dave Rawlings sound comes from a single instrument: a small-bodied 1935 Epiphone Olympic archtop guitar that he reportedly scavenged from a friend's garage and discovered the potential of only when he heard it through the studio microphones at one of Welch's early sessions. Rawlings plays it as a lead instrument, flatpicking single-note runs rather than strumming behind the singer, reaching for harp-like overlapping notes and the unexpected intervals that make a simple mountain-ballad chord change suddenly bloom. Critics put his playing in a line with Norman Blake, Doc Watson, and Jerry Garcia. On a long, exploratory track like "Pilgrim," that guitar is doing a lot of the roving.

A Led Zeppelin Connection

The best piece of trivia for a fan of this band is its live history. The Dave Rawlings Machine toured as a near-three-hour roots revue, and for several tour runs in the 2013 to 2016 era its mandolin player was John Paul Jones, the founding bassist of Led Zeppelin. Welch and Rawlings had first met Jones at the MerleFest festival in North Carolina years earlier, and a signature live

moment of the era was the band covering Led Zeppelin's "Going to California" with Jones himself on mandolin. One caveat for completists: Jones appears only in the special-thanks credits of Nashville Obsolete, not as a studio player on the album itself.

These Songs Take Their Time

"Pilgrim" is not even the longest track on the record. The album also contains "The Trip," which runs ten minutes and fifty-five seconds, a song Welch has said she essentially "spat out" in about twenty minutes. Six of the album's seven songs run well past four minutes. The unhurried, narrative-driven length is a deliberate aesthetic choice, and "Pilgrim" is its fullest expression.

Cultural Context

The Pilgrim Has Been Walking a Long Time

The wandering pilgrim is one of the oldest and deepest motifs in American roots music, and "Pilgrim (You Can't Go Home)" is in direct conversation with it. The traditional spiritual "I Am a Poor Wayfaring Stranger," whose lyrics were first printed in 1858, depicts a solitary pilgrim's hard passage through a world of woe toward an afterlife of rest. Its modal, often unaccompanied melody traces back to the Scots-Irish immigrants who carried border ballads into the Southern Appalachians, where themes of displacement and longing for home took deep root. That motif runs straight through Sacred Harp shape-note singing, gospel, and the Carter Family tradition. What Rawlings and Welch add is the very American, Thomas Wolfe-flavored twist in the parenthetical: you can't go home again. The song takes a two-hundred-year-old archetype of the journey through life as exile and sharpens it into a statement about the impossibility of return.

Architects of a Revival, Not Followers

It is easy to file Dave Rawlings Machine alongside the banjo-and-kick-drum folk acts that dominated pop radio in the early 2010s, but the timeline runs the other way. Gillian Welch performed on, and served as associate music producer of, the soundtrack to the Coen Brothers' O Brother, Where Art Thou? in 2000. That album, assembled by T Bone Burnett, sold eight times platinum and beat OutKast, U2, and Bob Dylan for the 2002 Album of the Year Grammy, and it created a mass audience for old-time and roots music more or less overnight. Welch and Rawlings were not riding that revival. They were among the artists who set it off. By the time Mumford & Sons broke big in the United States around 2010, and the Lumineers' "Ho Hey" was chasing Rihanna up the charts in late 2012, the genuine traditionalists had been at work for more than a decade. Nashville Obsolete, arriving in 2015, is a record by the credible old-time core that the mainstream wave had commercialized. The album's title is a wry comment on exactly that tension, between the vintage and the modern, the analog and the obsolete.

If You Liked This

Two directions to go from here. First, deeper into the Welch and Rawlings catalog, then outward to the wider Americana family the song belongs to.

Stay With Welch and Rawlings

- **Time (The Revelator), Gillian Welch (2001).** The consensus masterpiece. If the long, hypnotic, narrative-ballad form of "Pilgrim" is what hooked you, go straight to its fifteen-minute closer "I Dream a Highway." This is the essential album.
- **The Harrow & the Harvest, Gillian Welch (2011).** The spare, two-guitar Welch-billed counterpart to the lush Machine sound, made after an eight-year perfectionist silence. The bones of the songwriting, without the string section.
- **Woodland, Gillian Welch & David Rawlings (2024).** Their Grammy-winning return, made in the studio a tornado nearly destroyed. The natural next chapter after the Machine era closed.

Branch Out Into the Family Tree

- **Old Crow Medicine Show, O.C.M.S. (2004).** The closest stylistic cousin and a literal collaborator. Rawlings co-wrote "Wagon Wheel" with Ketch Secor and produced the band's early records.
- **The Avett Brothers, I and Love and You (2009).** Released the same year as the Machine's debut, the album that pushed the Avetts into the new folk revival. Earnest, harmony-driven, narrative songwriting.
- **Iris DeMent, Infamous Angel (1992).** Plainspoken, gospel-tinged Appalachian songwriting. The closest match for the haunted, modal, hymn-like quality of "Pilgrim" itself.
- **Jason Isbell, Southeastern (2013).** The confessional alt-country wing of the same family tree, for a listener who responds to the weight and storytelling but wants something more contemporary.
- **Willie Watson, Folk Singer Vol. 1 (2014).** A Dave Rawlings Machine band member's album of traditional songs, mapping almost exactly onto the old-time material the Machine plays live.

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